

StarOffice is back with its 'new improved' version. Let's find out if it's worth ditching MS Office yet

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You've been constant companions through the years—been together during the good times and seen each other through the bad. We're not talking about your childhood buddy or your pet dog. For most of us Microsoft Office is the 'one and only' solution to all our desktop processing needs, whether it's that assignment that's going to get you a top grade or a presentation that's going to help you close a deal.

But hey, wait! StarOffice is back with its 'new improved' version and it's ready to take on Office! So can StarOffice do all that Office can?

Customising StarOffice: Like Office, StarOffice applications have a common customisation interface that can be accessed from Tools > Options. Here, apart from the obvious customisation options such as user information, printer, security, language or font settings, you can customise the look and feel of StarOffice. For instance, you can give StarOffice a Macintosh or an OS/2 look and feel, set mouse scrolling and positioning, get the middle button of your mouse to act as a scrollbar, etc. Global settings for all StarOffice applications can be done from this one dialog box.

Tools > Configure lets you configure the functions

A Window to StarOffice 6.0



Probably not. But the important thing is, can it do the tasks you most depend on Office for? Let's find out.

Kick(Star)ting Office 6.0

StarOffice is a free office suite from Sun Microsystems which runs on Windows 9x, Me, NT, 2000 and XP. It also runs on Linux and Solaris platforms. If you've used StarOffice 5.2 and often found yourself cursing its 'integrated desktop'—well, its long gone.

StarOffice 6 behaves better and has as good a design as Office.

The StarOffice suite comes packed with a word processor, a spreadsheet, an HTML editor, presentation and a drawing tool. Each application runs separately and you can launch them either from the Start menu or Quickstarter in the system tray.

you want on your menus or change keyboard shortcut keys and configure your status bar. Toolbars can be knocked off in this dialog or through View > Toolbars and you can also customise the toolbar by clicking on Customise in the same menu or simply right-click the toolbar and select visible buttons to uncheck the buttons you don't want. You can also view your document as a print layout (that's the default layout in Writer), online layout and a full screen layout.

You can even customise toolbar buttons and set functions to them. Get rid of those old buttons and create your own (make sure they are in BMP format, sized 30x30 pixels and don't have more than 256 colours) and add them to 'staroffice6.0/share/config/Icon' directory—every time the Buttons bar is clicked, StarOffice will automatically search for new icons in that folder.

Template management: Like MS Office, StarOffice also has a template management interface. This can be started through the Quickstarter in the system tray. StarOffice doesn't have as many readymade template choices as Office but its

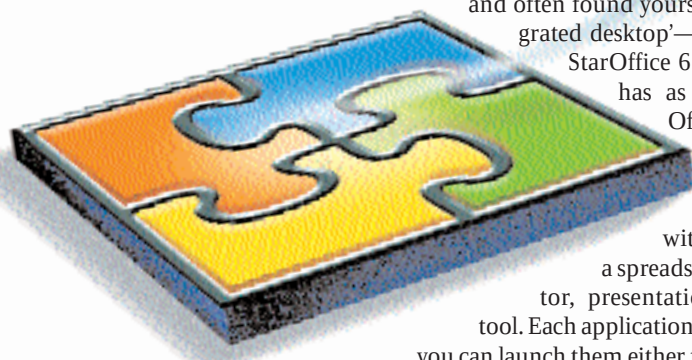


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